

Are you batty for birds? Check this out



Lee Calvert/Special to The Gazette

Dolly Parton has taken a stand to protect endangered birds.

By Lee Calvert
Special to The Gazette

Do majestic birds of prey make your heart soar?

If they do, you don't have to drive far to see these splendid creatures. The Carolina Raptor Center, located just north of Charlotte, and Dollywood, located in East Tennessee, both offer spectacular habitats for birds of prey.

Dollywood, the theme park co-owned by celebrity Dolly Parton, recently dedicated a four-section complex devoted entirely to eagles. The complex is operated by Dollywood and the National Foundation to Protect American Eagles, (NFPAE), a non-profit organization.

The complex houses the Eagle Mountain Sanctuary, a specially designed habitat for disabled eagles unable to survive in the wild. The Wings of America Theater showcases live birds of prey. Trained professionals from the NFPAE explain how the audience can make the environment safer for not only the birds, but for ourselves as well.

Bird-handlers stress the importance of recycling, avoidance of dangerous chemicals and pesticides, proper disposal of waste materials and the maintenance of eagle's natural habitats.

Facilities devoted to eagle breeding and rehabilitation are not open to the public. In these private sections of the complex, new eaglets will be hatched and

veterinarians will rehabilitate injured birds.

Just like Dollywood, the Carolina Raptor Center is doing its part to rehabilitate injured birds of prey and educate the public.

The Center opened in 1980 on the University of North Carolina at Charlotte campus. In 1981, it was incorporated as a private non-profit organization and in 1984 moved onto 57 acres of donated land at Latta Plantation Park. Since then, the Raptor center has rehabilitated hundreds of birds.

More than 500,000 people have visited the Raptor center. School groups visit the Center's live bird show. Birds of prey also

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inhabit the Raptor Center's nature trail, which is open to the public.

In May of last year, two golden eagles successfully hatched and raised a young eaglet, the first chick of its kind hatched in North Carolina history.

The Raptor Center also participates in a Bold Eagle Census, a Hawk Watch on the N.C. coast in the fall and an adopt-a-bird of prey program.

The Raptor Center also has broken ground for a new Environmental Education Center. Expansion plans include a new

hospital for injured birds, new breeding facilities offices and an expanded gift shop.

Both Dollywood and The Carolina Raptor Center have taken on an awesome task — the protection and presentation of these majestic birds of prey. If we don't stop environmental destruction now, the only place future generations will be able to view majestic birds of prey will be in museums.

■ WANT TO LEARN MORE?

For further information, contact Dollywood, 700 Dollywood Lane, Pigeon Forge, Tenn., 37863, or call 615-428-9488. You can also contact Carolina Raptor Center, Pat Marcum, Executive Director, P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, N.C. 28297, or call 704-875-6521.